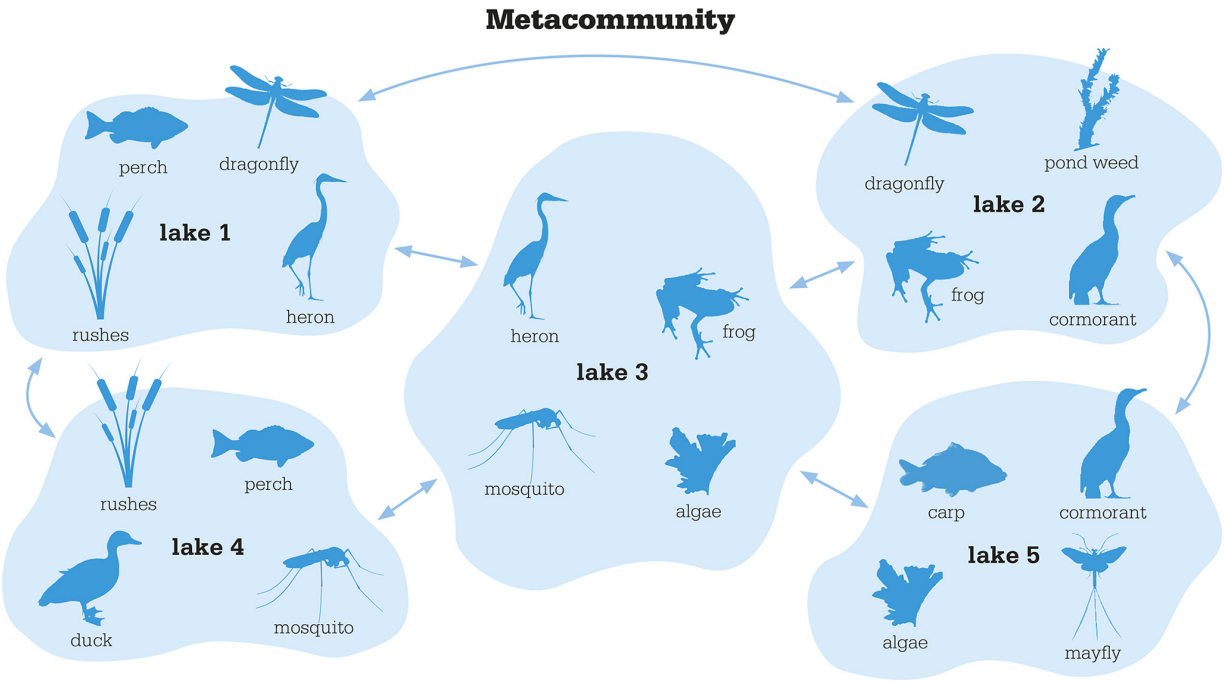


In this example of a metacommunity, arrows show how species move between lakes to feed or breed. Seeds and the spores of algae are dispersed by the wind.

Read accessible description

Finding metacommunities

One of the problems with Leibold's concept is that in practice it is not so straightforward to identify the separate components of a metacommunity. For the fish and other water creatures in different lakes within a lake district, for instance, each lake may clearly be a distinct community. However, for those birds able to fly between the lakes in minutes, the different lakes are all part of the same single community. This may explain why much of the continuing work and research on metacommunities has been theoretical and abstract rather than rooted in fieldwork. Some metacommunities are easy to identify, such as islands in an island group, or tidal pools that are separate between tides but joined when the tide comes in. In their 2004 paper, Leibold and his colleagues acknowledged that local